Chess and India's Grandmasters

Introduction to Chess and Its Indian Roots

Chess is a two-player strategy board game played on a board of 64 squares, with each player controlling 16 pieces: a king, a queen, two rooks, two bishops, two knights and eight pawns. The aim is to checkmate the opponent's king, which means attacking it in such a way that it cannot escape. Chess is widely believed to have originated in India around the 6th century CE, in the Gupta period, as a game called chaturanga, which means "four divisions" of the army: infantry, cavalry, elephants and chariots, which became the pawn, knight, bishop and rook. The game then spread to Persia, where it was called shatranj, and through the Arab world to Europe, where it evolved into its modern form in the 15th century. World Chess Day is celebrated on 20 July, the day the International Chess Federation (FIDE) was founded in 1924. FIDE awards titles such as Candidate Master, FIDE Master, International Master and the highest, Grandmaster (GM), which requires a rating above 2500 and three GM norms.

Who Was India's First Grandmaster?

India's first Grandmaster is Viswanathan Anand, who earned the title in 1988, at age 18, from Chennai. Born on 11 December 1969 in Mayiladuthurai in Tamil Nadu and raised in Chennai, he is known as the "Tiger of Madras" and is celebrated for his fast, intuitive playing style, which led him to be called the "Lightning Kid". Anand became India's first Grandmaster in 1988, and in 1987 he had become the first Indian World Junior Champion. He won the FIDE World Championship in 2000, then won the undisputed World Chess Championship in 2007 in Mexico City, and defended the title in 2008 against Vladimir Kramnik in Bonn, in 2010 against Veselin Topalov in Sofia and in 2012 against Boris Gelfand in Moscow, making him a five-time World Champion. He lost the title to Magnus Carlsen in 2013 in a match held in Chennai. Anand was the first recipient of the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna award in 1991-92, was awarded the Padma Vibhushan in 2007, and is a mentor to many young players through the Westbridge Anand Chess Academy. Until Anand, chess in India had a few titled players: Manuel Aaron of Chennai became India's first International Master in 1961, and was a key pioneer.

Why Is Chennai Called India's Chess Capital?

Chennai is called the chess capital of India because it has produced more chess grandmasters and champions than any other Indian city, with Tamil Nadu producing a very large share of India's Grandmasters, around a third of the more than 85 Indian Grandmasters. The reasons are a strong chess culture, many coaching academies, clubs and schools, and the inspiration provided by Viswanathan Anand. The Tamil Nadu State Chess Association, which holds frequent tournaments, supports young talent, and chess is taught in many schools. Manuel Aaron and the pioneers of the 1960s and 1970s built the foundation. Famous Grandmasters from Chennai and Tamil Nadu include V. Anand, D. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, R. Vaishali, Aravindh Chithambaram, B. Adhiban, S. P. Sethuraman and Karthikeyan Murali, and Women Grandmaster S. Vijayalakshmi. The Chennai region hosted the 2013 World Championship match between Anand and Carlsen and the 44th Chess Olympiad in 2022. In 2022, Chennai and neighbouring Mahabalipuram became world famous when India hosted the Olympiad for the first time.

What Is the Chess Olympiad?

The Chess Olympiad is a biennial team chess competition organised by FIDE, in which national teams from around the world compete in open and women's sections, with each team having five players. It is the biggest team chess event in the world. The first official Olympiad was held in London in 1927, and since then it has been held every two years. The 44th Chess Olympiad was held from 28 July to 9 August 2022 at Mahabalipuram near Chennai, the first time India hosted the event, and the first time it was held in India, following Russia's removal from hosting because of the war in Ukraine; the torch relay was started in India for the first time, and the official mascot was Thambi, a horse in a Tamil dhoti and shirt. India won bronze medals in both the open and women's sections, and Uzbekistan won the open section and Ukraine won the women's section. At the 45th Olympiad in Budapest, Hungary, in September 2024, India won gold medals in both the open and women's sections for the first time in history, with a team including D. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi, Vidit Gujrathi and Pentala Harikrishna in the open section, and Harika Dronavalli, Divya Deshmukh, Vaishali, Vantika Agrawal and Tania Sachdev in the women's.

The Rise of Indian Chess

India has a great generation of young players. D. Gukesh, born in Chennai in 2006, became the youngest ever challenger to win the Candidates Tournament in April 2024 in Toronto at the age of 17, and then became the youngest undisputed World Champion at age 18 on 12 December 2024, defeating Ding Liren of China in Singapore. R. Praggnanandhaa, born in Chennai in 2005, became a Grandmaster at age 12, and defeated world number one Magnus Carlsen in a rapid game in February 2022, and reached the final of the 2023 Chess World Cup, where he finished second to Carlsen. R. Vaishali, his sister, became a Grandmaster in 2023, making them the first brother-sister Grandmaster pair in history. Divya Deshmukh won the Women's World Cup in July 2025 and became a Grandmaster, and Koneru Humpy won the world rapid title in 2024. India now has a large number of Grandmasters, one of the highest in the world.

Benefits of Chess

Chess improves concentration, memory, planning, problem-solving, patience and sportsmanship. Many schools in Tamil Nadu include chess in their curriculum, and the state government has promoted it. Online platforms like Chess.com and Lichess, along with the Netflix-popularised interest in the game, led to a boom after 2020. Artificial intelligence changed chess when IBM's Deep Blue defeated Garry Kasparov in 1997, and engines like Stockfish and AlphaZero now play better than any human.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include limited funding for young players, travel costs and the need for coaches. India is now a chess superpower, and with its new champions and large youth base the future looks bright.

Quick Facts

- Viswanathan Anand became India's first Grandmaster in 1988 and a five-time World Champion.
- Chennai is called India's chess capital because it has produced a large share of India's Grandmasters.
- The 44th Chess Olympiad was held at Mahabalipuram near Chennai in 2022; India won gold in both sections in 2024.
- D. Gukesh became the youngest World Champion on 12 December 2024.
- Chess originated in India as chaturanga around the 6th century CE.